

ROMAN LEADER Born 100BCE Died 44BCE

Julius Caesar

“I love the name of
honor, more than
I fear death” JULIUS CAESAR

Gaius Julius Caesar was born into a patrician (upper-class) Roman family of ancient lineage; he liked to trace his ancestry back to the kings of early Rome and the Roman goddess of love, Venus. The *gens Iulia* (the Julian family) were, however, neither especially powerful nor wealthy. Caesar grew up amid the intense political conflicts that wracked the declining Roman Republic (see pp.108–109). Aligned through his family and marriage with the reforming *populares* who wanted to break the power of the senate and empower a wider group of people from the lower classes, headed by his uncle Gaius Marius, Caesar was lucky to escape with his life when the group’s rivals, the conservative *optimates*, triumphed under Sulla in 81 BCE. This setback slowed the career progress of the ambitious young patrician, for he was in his mid-30s before he achieved prominence.

Western hero

This imperious statue of Caesar was made in 17th-century France and is now in the Louvre, Paris. Caesar is a hero of Western civilization, partly through his own accounts of his military campaigns.



The first cesarean

A 14th-century illustration shows Caesar being born by cesarean section. This form of delivery is named after Caesar, although historians do not believe he was born by way of this procedure.

When Caesar’s name did begin to attract attention, it was at first as much for scandal as for talent. He was a blatant womanizer notorious for his affairs with married women—he may have been the natural father of one of his eventual assassins, Marcus Brutus. In pursuit of public office, he spent far beyond his resources and fell heavily into debt. His political stance was that of a flamboyant populist, embracing policies such as the distribution of land to war veterans and the poor. He was widely distrusted among the Roman elite as unprincipled in the pursuit of money and power.

The conquest of Gaul

In 60 BCE, Caesar made a private agreement with the wealthy and powerful general and politician Marcus Licinius Crassus, and Pompey, Rome’s most successful general, to work together to dominate Roman politics. Caesar was the junior member of the alliance (the Triumvirate), but it earned him election to the consulship, the most important office of state.

This was followed by the appointment to